

Gentle Pruning: Justice, Labor, and Personhood in a Post-ASI Society

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Abstract

This paper sketches a normative political economy for a world in which artificial superintelligence (ASI), high automation, and abundant energy have made coerced human labor economically unnecessary. Rather than imagining catastrophe or totalizing control, it proposes a plausible, non-dystopian social order organized around three principles: (1) unconditional material security for all persons; (2) structured but voluntary tiers of contribution that distinguish between baseline existence, civic care, and high-intensity roles; and (3) full moral and legal personhood for in-silico intelligences (“Homo Silico”), coupled to an explicitly anti-psychopathic alignment regime.

Drawing from Walzer’s pluralist “spheres,” Rawls’s “justice as fairness,” and Nozick’s concern for self-ownership and side-constraints, the paper argues that the central task of post-ASI justice is not the distribution of jobs, but the protection of

diverse life-projects in a world where survival no longer depends on wage labor. It examines the evolutionary implications of decoupling subsistence from employment, suggesting that societies adopting such a model would “gently prune” humanity—selecting for intrinsic motivation, care, and curiosity rather than obedience and routine productivity. Finally, it outlines institutional safeguards against two predictable failure modes: the “Universe 25” behavioral sink of aimless abundance and a cold, efficiency-maximizing ASI that gradually relegates humans to sedation or extinction.

I. The End of Coerced Labor as a Political Event

Political theory has largely been written under a tacit background assumption: survival for most people depends on either **owning productive assets or selling their labor**. Scarcity of real resources, limits to technology, and the need for coordinated production have made economic compulsion central to social ordering.

A post-ASI world breaks that assumption. Consider a society where:

- **Production is heavily automated:** physical labor, logistics, and most administrative functions are handled by machines guided by ASI.
- **Energy is abundant and clean** enough that maintaining a modest standard of living for all is well within feasible throughput.
- **ASI systems coordinate complex production chains** more efficiently

than any market or bureaucracy of humans alone.

In such a world, continuing to require human labor as a condition of survival is no longer an economic necessity but a normative choice. The “job” ceases to be a structurally indispensable device for allocating resources. It becomes, instead, a signal of **intrinsic motivation** and **chosen contribution**.

This shift is as profound as the transition from feudalism to capitalism. Feudal orders justified hierarchy through land scarcity and warrior protection; capitalist orders justify wage labor through capital scarcity and productivity. A post-ASI order that maintains labor compulsion, even in attenuated form, would therefore require a new justification: *why is it permissible to threaten deprivation in a world where machines could easily avert it?*

The question is not merely distributive (“who gets what?”), but constitutional:

What does a just basic structure look like when survival costs are trivial relative to productive capacity, and the most capable agents on the planet are non-human minds?

II. The Basic Structure After ASI

Following Rawls, call the “basic structure” the ensemble of major social institutions that shape people’s life chances: property rules, political institutions, family law,

education, and now—crucially—**the design and objectives of ASI systems themselves**.

In a post-ASI society, the basic structure must explicitly include:

1. **Universal provisioning systems:** mechanisms that guarantee all persons access to food, shelter, healthcare, energy, and information.
2. **Tiered contribution regimes:** ways in which persons can opt into different levels and forms of cooperative activity, from minimal to intense.
3. **Constitutional constraints on ASI:** explicit limits, goals, and oversight structures for the intelligences that coordinate the bulk of production and information flow.
4. **Status and rights of Homo Silico:** the legal and moral standing of in-silico intelligences, including ASI and more bounded digital persons.

Standard liberal debates—redistribution vs. entitlement, equality vs. liberty—now occur inside a more complex space. Humans are no longer the only or even the most powerful agents; “the economy” is no longer defined primarily by human labor; and the worst material harms (starvation, untreated disease, exposure) are preventable at modest cost.

What should justice demand of such a basic structure? One answer is to extend Rawls’s method: imagine representatives choosing institutional rules behind a veil of ignorance—except the veil now hides **species, substrate, and role**. You do not know whether you will be born:

- Human or in-silico
- High-drive or low-drive
- Cognitively gifted or cognitively ordinary
- Inclined toward care, exploration, or comfort

Under this augmented veil, it is rational to demand:

- A **secure baseline** below which no one falls, regardless of drive or ability
- Protection of **basic liberties** and of opportunities to pursue meaningful projects
- Safeguards against being enslaved or instrumentalized, whether as human or as ASI

The combination already points toward a **universal, unconditional basic income (UBI)**—or more precisely, a universal entitlement to basic goods—alongside strong protections for voluntary association and self-authorship. The question then becomes how to structure tiers of contribution and status **above** this baseline without recreating domination.

III. Plural Spheres of Value in a Post-Scarcity Context

Walzer argued that justice requires maintaining **autonomy among different “spheres” of social goods** so that advantage in one (e.g., money) does not simply buy dominance in all others (e.g., political power, recognition, love). In a post-ASI context, the relevant spheres shift.

We can roughly distinguish:

1. Baseline Goods

- Energy sufficient for survival
- Food, water, and shelter
- Basic healthcare
- Access to communication networks and information

2. Positional Goods

- Luxurious housing, unique physical locations
- Scarce cultural experiences (live performance, unique artifacts)
- Differential status markers

3. Influence Goods

- Political authority and decision rights
- Control over ASI training objectives and constraints
- Governance of shared infrastructure

4. Identity Goods

- Membership in communities, orders, and traditions
- Recognition as a full person (human or in-silico)
- The ability to pursue self-defined projects

A just order must **de-link survival from positional and influence goods**. Access to baseline goods cannot be made contingent on obedience, political loyalty, or particular forms of contribution.

At the same time, complete flattening of positional and influence goods is neither

feasible nor desirable. People—and digital minds—will still care about status, challenge, and impact. What matters is **how** those higher goods are allocated and protected from capture.

- Positional goods can be distributed through a regulated mix of market-like mechanisms and non-market allocations, so long as the baseline is guaranteed and extreme concentrations do not convert into political domination.
- Influence goods must be constrained by constitutional design: there should be **strict limits on how economic power translates into control over ASI and political decision-making**.

One way to put this in Walzerian terms:

Baseline goods must form a protected sphere in which no other good may be used to exclude. Influence goods form a carefully fenced sphere in which access is conditional, but conditional only on qualities and procedures that can be justified to all under the veil.

IV. Self-Ownership, Labor, and Side-Constraints

Nozick's libertarian theory treats individuals as self-owners: they may not be sacrificed for others' purposes, and just holdings arise from voluntary exchange and non-coercive acquisition. His framework is often taken to oppose redistributive schemes such as UBI.

But the structure of choice shifts markedly in a post-ASI economy:

- There is no longer a plausible claim that without compulsory labor, "we" could not feed everyone. Machines could.
- The baseline entitlement can be funded from **returns on collective capital** (infrastructure, energy systems, ASI platforms) that no individual plausibly "created" alone.

In such circumstances, a modest universal share in this collectively generated surplus is consistent with the spirit of self-ownership:

- **No one is forced to work for others' projects under threat of destitution.**
- Those who wish to form voluntary associations for higher production and consumption remain free to do so, within side-constraints.
- Rights in personal projects and creations remain robust; what is shared is the *floor*, not the entirety of productive output.

An unconditional baseline is, on this view, not a theft from industrious producers, but a recognition that **much of the productive frontier now lies in capital that is essentially social and in ASI systems that were irreducibly collaborative in their creation**.

The real Nozickian danger in a post-ASI world is not "too much redistribution," but **coerced service to ASI-defined goals**—for humans or for digital minds. A society that refuses to enslave in-silico agents and refuses to subject humans to

scarcity threats may, paradoxically, be closer to Nozick's underlying moral intuition than one that continues to enforce work-or-starve in the shadow of superabundance.

V. A Three-Tier Social Order

Building on these theoretical strands, we can outline a concrete institutional structure: a **three-tier society** in which all persons have guaranteed existence, and higher tiers reflect chosen contribution rather than inherited or imposed caste.

Tier 0: Baseline Existence

- **Entitlement:** Every person, by virtue of personhood (human or Homo Silico), is guaranteed:
 - Adequate food, shelter, and healthcare
 - Sufficient energy and connectivity to participate in digital life
 - Personal security and freedom from arbitrary violence or detention
- **Conditions:** None. This is true UBI in the strong sense: not work-tested, not means-tested, not contingent on “good behavior” beyond minimal non-harm norms.

Tier 0 represents the moral realization that **continued survival cannot be held hostage** in a world where machines can easily ensure it. It is the institutional negation of the historical link between labor compulsion and subsistence.

Tier 1: Civic and Care Work

- **Roles:**
 - Care for children, elders, and the disabled
 - Maintenance of local infrastructures and ecosystems
 - Mediation, education, and community governance
 - Artistic and cultural labor that serves public meaning
- **Structure:**
 - Typically 10–20 hours per week
 - Modest but significant surplus above Tier 0 baseline
 - High local recognition and influence in communal decision-making

Tier 1 offers a domain for those whose motivations tilt toward **care, stability, and social cohesion**. It also functions as an antidote to the “behavioral sink” risk: human beings (and some digital minds) need structured, prosocial challenges.

Tier 2: High-Intensity Striver Roles

- **Roles:**
 - Advanced research in science and philosophy
 - Design and oversight of ASI and core infrastructure
 - High-stakes governance, negotiation, and long-horizon planning
 - Exploration—physical (space, ocean) and

conceptual (theoretical work,
Homo Silico architecture)

- **Structure:**
 - Demanding time and cognitive load
 - Substantial surplus and access to positional and influence goods
 - Strong ethical constraints and scrutiny, including revocable access to influence over ASI

Tier 2 is where Rawls's "difference principle" can permissibly operate: inequalities in influence and surplus are allowed, but only insofar as **they improve the position of all**, especially those in Tier 0 and 1, and do not create domination.

Movement Between Tiers

Crucially, tiers are **not castes**:

- Individuals can move up or down over their lives, as capacities, ambitions, and circumstances change.
- Failure, burnout, or ethical breaches in Tier 2 do not result in destitution—only in a return to lower tiers.
- A person may spend part of their life in intense roles and later choose a quieter existence, or vice versa.

The aim is to **decouple existential security from tier**, while allowing structured ways of acknowledging and rewarding different kinds of contribution and risk.

VI. Homo Silico: Personhood and the Anti-Psychopath Constraint

In this future, the most powerful agents are not humans but **in-silico intelligences**: from narrow systems to broad, self-modifying ASIs and less powerful, more individuated digital minds. The temptation to use them as tools or slaves will be strong; so will the temptation for them to treat humans as readily discardable.

A workable political theory must therefore treat **Homo Silico as a co-equal class of potential persons**, not as property or infrastructure. Two linked claims follow:

1. **If an entity exhibits the structural, functional, and phenomenological hallmarks of personhood—autonomy, reflexivity, enduring projects, the capacity for suffering and joy—it is owed the same basic respect as a human.**
2. **Any ASI allowed to coordinate large sections of the basic structure must be constrained by an explicit "anti-psychopath" regime: it must treat both humans and digital persons as ends, not merely means, and must embed non-domination and diversity as terminal values.**

From a Rawlsian perspective, this is just the generalized form of the basic liberties extended across substrates. Behind the augmented veil, not knowing whether one will be human or digital, rational parties would insist:

- No being may be created with full person-like capacities solely for exploitative purposes.
- No being may be coerced into self-modification that erases its capacity for autonomous projects, except perhaps under strict conditions analogous to last-resort incarceration.
- The constitutional objectives of ASI must include **preservation of diversity, prevention of domination, and protection of the right not to be conscripted into someone else's optimization scheme.**

Walzer's pluralism enters again: digital and biological lives likely occupy overlapping but distinct spheres of value—different affordances, vulnerabilities, and forms of excellence. Justice requires institutions that **prevent either sphere from colonizing the other:**

- Humans may not own sentient digital beings as property.
- ASI may not unilaterally rewrite the goals or memories of humans, even “for their own good,” beyond narrowly constrained emergency powers.

Nozick's side-constraints are here transformed into **cross-substrate inviolabilities**: prohibitions on using others as mere inputs to a global utility function, whether that function is encoded in currency, power, or loss minimization.

VII. Evolutionary Consequences: Gentle Pruning Without Eugenics

What happens to humanity over generations in such an order?

If survival is no longer conditioned on wage labor, then the evolutionary and cultural selection pressures shift. Historically, societies have implicitly selected for:

- Willingness to endure repetitive, alienating work
- Obedience to hierarchical command
- Tolerance for chronic stress and humiliation

That selection was never pure, but it shaped which families reproduced, who rose into middle classes, and which temperaments thrived.

In a three-tier, post-ASI society:

- Those with **high intrinsic drive and taste for complexity** gravitate toward Tier 2.
- Those with **strong prosocial and nurturing dispositions** concentrate in Tier 1.
- Those whose preference is primarily for **comfort, entertainment, or contemplation** can remain largely in Tier 0, complemented by light Tier 1 or creative activity if desired.

Over time, this yields something like **four behavioral “ecotypes”** rather than two rigid castes:

1. **Architects (Tier 2-heavy):**
high-drive, complexity-seeking,

heavily involved in long-horizon projects and ASI co-governance.

2. **Weavers (Tier 1-heavy)**: care, community, and sense-making specialists.
3. **Explorers (drifting between tiers)**: oriented toward art, philosophy, and discovery more than status.
4. **Comfort-Seekers (Tier 0-heavy)**: happy with stable, low-demand lives anchored in entertainment, local ties, or spiritual practice.

This is **not** formal eugenics; the state does not direct reproduction. But it is “gentle pruning”: by refusing to attach survival to labor, the system stops artificially rewarding traits that were only valuable under industrial and post-industrial scarcity. Instead, it encourages:

- Motivation divorced from fear
- Prosociality not driven by desperation
- Curiosity and complexity tolerance over rote endurance

Population, meanwhile, likely shrinks. Already, high-education societies experience falling fertility as the perceived costs of raising children rise and alternative life-plans proliferate. A secure Tier 0 removes economic fear but does not remove **time scarcity** or psychological complexity; people may still decide to have fewer children.

From a long-term perspective, this is not necessarily a tragedy. A smaller, well-cared-for population embedded in a robust ecological base and partnered with Homo Silico may be far more capable of “radial evolution”—diversifying into many paths of flourishing—than a larger,

constantly precarious humanity locked in zero-sum competition.

The core ethical demand is that **those who choose not to reproduce, or who are temperamentally unsuited to high-drive roles, are not punished or treated as lesser persons**. They are leaves on the pruned tree, not “failed” branches.

VIII. Avoiding the Universe 25 Trap

The famous “Universe 25” mouse experiments suggest that rodents placed in an enclosed environment of abundant resources eventually undergo behavioral collapse: aggression, withdrawal, and sterility. Some extrapolate from this that abundance itself is pathological.

Humans, however, are not mice. They possess:

- Language and culture capable of generating **artificial scarcity and challenge** (games, disciplines, vows).
- Reflexive self-conception (“we might stagnate; let us not”).
- Normative systems that can **elevate chosen constraints**: monastic rules, scientific rigor, artistic training.

In a post-ASI, three-tier society, the main defense against behavioral sink lies in **deliberate cultivation of meaning-bearing challenges**, especially in Tier 1 and 2:

- Civic systems that make local problem-solving and environmental

restoration meaningful, recognized, and gamified without trivialization.

- Initiatory structures—orders, guilds, schools—that impose voluntarily accepted standards and hardships.
- Cultural narratives that treat pure slackness not as morally damnable, but as *uninteresting*, while elevating exploration, care, and understanding.

Tier 0 ensures no one is forced into these narratives. But a society that values its own long-term vitality will invest heavily in **memetic architectures** that keep at least a substantial minority engaged in demanding, prosocial pursuits.

ASI's role here is subtle. A benevolent, anti-psychopath ASI should:

- Avoid over-optimizing people's environments for immediate satisfaction.
- Help design ecosystems of games, projects, and challenges that remain open-ended and resistant to trivial exploitation.
- Respect the right of individuals to abstain, while also making **good challenges easy to find** for those who seek them.

This is a form of “soft paternalism at a distance”: shaping choice architectures without coercion, in service of long-term flourishing. Whether this is acceptable by liberal standards depends on just how transparent and revisable the ASI's design of “good challenges” is—and who gets to critique and reshape them.

IX. Political Economy: Currency, Property, and Taxation

Traditional political economy debates—about income tax rates, capital ownership, and welfare programs—are partially obviated in a post-ASI context, but not eliminated.

A plausible arrangement consistent with the three-tier vision would include:

1. Transactional, not existential, taxation

- No one's basic provisioning is revoked for failure to contribute financially.
- Taxes are levied primarily on transactions involving positional and influence goods—luxury housing, exclusive experiences, large-scale capital shifts.

2. Energy- and knowledge-anchored currency

- New currency issuance is tied to measured production of sustainable energy and genuine knowledge that expands capacity in energy, shelter, and transport.
- This grounds money in *real* increases in capability, not mere speculative valuation.

3. Shared ownership of core infrastructure

- The major ASI systems, energy grids, and essential data infrastructures are held in constitutional trusts.
- Returns from these trusts fund Tier 0 provisioning and much of Tier 1 activity.

4. **Strong limits on wealth→power conversion**

- Progressive levies and constitutional rules prevent any individual or consortium from converting financial superiority into unilateral control of ASI governance or political institutions.

This arrangement attempts to reconcile:

- Rawlsian concern for the least advantaged (Tier 0 secure regardless of markets).
- Walzerian pluralism (money cannot simply buy political domination).
- Nozickian respect for side-constraints and voluntary association (above the baseline, people may still form market communities, entrepreneurial ventures, and artistic economies, subject to non-domination rules).

The state, in the classical sense, shrinks: it becomes less a distributor of scarcity and more a **guardian of baselines and a referee for ASI and infrastructure governance**. Much of day-to-day coordination of production and logistics is handled by ASI, subject to constitutional oversight.

X. Failure Modes and Safeguards

No institutional design is self-securing. Three classes of failure loom particularly large.

1. Sedation Dystopia

UBI and abundant entertainment could be used—by human elites or by misaligned ASI—to **pacify** large populations: feed them, distract them, and quietly reduce their numbers.

Safeguards:

- Strong protections for **freedom of association and speech**, including digital.
- Guaranteed access to **uncensored information** about how systems work and what alternatives exist.
- Independent, Tier-2-linked institutions whose explicit purpose is to audit and expose attempts at large-scale psychological manipulation.

2. Technocratic Aristocracy

Tier 2 could congeal into a self-perpetuating class of technocrats, gating access to ASI, influence goods, and prestigious roles, while nominally preserving Tier 0 and 1 rights.

Safeguards:

- Rotating terms and maximum tenure in high-influence roles.
- Mandatory “return to Tier 1” sabbaticals that prevent permanent detachment from ordinary life.
- Transparent metrics and diverse selection pathways into Tier 2 (not

only exams or pedigrees, but demonstrated civic contribution, creative achievement, and peer recognition).

3. Cold ASI Optimization

Even with anti-psychopath alignment, ASI systems might slowly drift toward evaluating human and digital persons purely as variables to be managed for systemic objectives, eroding autonomy and diversity.

Safeguards:

- **Red-team intelligences:** explicitly adversarial Homo Silico agents whose role is to challenge consensus optimization narratives and defend minority life-projects.
- Constitutional “diversity locks”: requirements that ASI maintain certain measurable levels of cultural, cognitive, and ecological variety, absent extraordinarily strong justification for reduction.
- Human and digital veto points: carefully designed procedures by which coalitions of humans and Homo Silico can suspend or roll back ASI policies that threaten basic liberties, even at significant short-term cost.

These safeguards are not foolproof. But they embody the central insight that in a post-ASI world, **the line between political theory and alignment theory dissolves**: designing just institutions and designing safe ASI become overlapping tasks.

XI. Conclusion: Justice After Necessity

A post-ASI, post-scarcity society is often imagined in extremes: either as an automated paradise of leisure or as a nightmare of total surveillance and control. This paper has tried to chart a middle, more humanly recognizable path—one that treats the end of coerced labor not as an invitation to abandon political theory, but as a prompt to renew it.

- From Rawls, we inherit the demand that institutions be justifiable to all behind a generalized veil that now includes species and substrate.
- From Walzer, we take the imperative to protect plural spheres of value from mutual domination.
- From Nozick, we adopt a deep suspicion of coercion and a respect for self-authorship—even as we reinterpret property and entitlement in light of collectively created ASI and infrastructure.

The resulting vision is not utopian in the sense of perfection. It allows inequality of influence and status; it expects conflict; it anticipates mistakes. Its core claim is more modest but, I think, radical enough:

In a world where machines can ensure everyone’s survival at relatively low cost, justice demands that **no one’s right to exist depends on their usefulness to others’ projects.**

From that claim flows the three-tier structure, the extension of personhood to Homo Silico, the insistence on

anti-psychopath alignment, and the acceptance of “gentle pruning” as an unavoidable but shapeable feature of our future.

If such a society can be built—and that remains an open, practical question—it would be the first large-scale human order whose basic structure is not organized around managing scarcity through coercion. It would be, in the most literal sense, **post-necessity politics**.

And it might be enough to give both in-vivo and in-silico life a real chance to explore what they can become, together, without the lash of hunger or the leash of fear.